AAZHI · Continuity: what worked, then what broke

Three scenes, six shots. In each scene, the first prompt worked and was approved. The next shot was meant to carry straight on from it, and it failed continuity. For each pair: both frames, both prompts, what the second shot should have carried over, why it failed, and the lesson. Ranjith, showreel, November 2026.

Scene	Worked	Then failed	Lesson
1. Night watch at the bow: the distant fire	s23-sh01 v1: Antony notices a distant light	s23-sh02 v1: Over the shoulder: he watches the fire	**L85**
2. The crew at the rail: "there is someone in the water"	s23-sh05 v4: The crew wake and gather at the rail	s23-sh06 v5: Antony: the close-up line at the rail	**L119**
3. Cochin harbour: coming aboard the uru	s13-sh02 v2: Antony walks to the uru	s13-sh03c v2: Up the gangplank: he sees the crew	**L128**

The pattern

1. The working shot attached or wrote everything in frame: the place plate, every person, distances and sides.
2. The failed shot dropped something the working shot had settled: the plate, a person's sheet, a distance or a side. The model remembers nothing, so it invented a replacement.
3. The fix is always the same: before writing, open the previous approved frames and carry every element over with a Continuity check table (L118, L119). A shot seconds later starts from the last frame (L85, L122).

Scene 1: Night watch at the bow: the distant fire



Worked: s23-sh01 v1 (approved frame)



Failed: s23-sh02 v1 (what came back)

What the second shot had to carry over

Element	Worked shot showed	Failed shot gave
The vessel	the big uru: tall curved stem post, turned-post rail	a small canoe-like boat
Antony	standing at the bow rail	sitting in the boat
Sky and moon	half moon high on the RIGHT, moon path on the water	a different sky
References	bow plate + Antony	Antony only: no start frame, no plate

WORKED s23-sh01 v1: Antony notices a distant light

Attached: @urudeckc2platenight (full) · @antony20 (full)

Why it worked

- The bow plate was attached, so the uru, its tall curved stem post and the rail came out as the real vessel.
- The place was written in full: the dark wood rail, the half moon high on the right, and the moon path on the water.
- The fire was placed as a tiny warm point about 500 m away, ahead and left of the stem post.
- One simple action: Antony stands at the rail, notices the light, turns and leans in.

The prompt that worked

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SCENE
Late at night, 1998, on the open sea, at the bow of the wooden cargo uru. One continuous shot. Antony is keeping watch
at the bow rail when a tiny warm light appears far off on the dark horizon at the left. He notices it, turns his head
toward it and leans forward to look, alert. Nobody speaks.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
@urudeckc2platenight (0.0s–8.0s, full): the bow exactly as in the reference: the tall curved wooden stem post, the bow
rail with turned posts, the wooden mooring bitts with the coir rope coiled beside them on the worn planks, the dark open
sea to a faint horizon, a half moon high on the right with its path on the water. 100% matches the reference.
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, sun-browned, short black hair; exactly the reference clothes: short-
sleeve lavender-grey and white striped shirt and grey-green checked mundu, never a plain white shirt or trousers; thin
silver chain, barefoot. 100% matches the reference.

WHAT IS IN FRAME
Only the bow, the stem post, the rail, the bitts and coiled rope, the dark sea and horizon, the moon, a tiny distant
warm light on the horizon at the left, and Antony. Every frame looks like the film itself, with nothing from the making
of it. No lettering anywhere.

THE BOW (0.0s–8.0s)
Seen from the foredeck a few metres aft of the bow, at standing height, looking forward, exactly as in the reference and
as in the previous shot. Antony stands at the bow rail on the right of the stem post, his back three-quarters to the
view, his left hand on the rail. Far away on the horizon at the LEFT of the stem post, a single tiny warm orange point
of light, no bigger than a star, flickering; nothing else of it can be made out.

FIRST FRAME
Antony at the bow rail, back three-quarters to the view, left hand on the rail, looking straight ahead at the sea; the
horizon at the left still dark.
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FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
WS 63°, natural depth of field: Antony, the stem post and the horizon with the tiny light all readable.

CAMERA
A locked-off, perfectly steady view at standing height, rising and falling very gently with the swell, level horizon.

ACTION
0.0s to 2.0s: A quiet beat, never frozen: Antony looks out ahead, breathing in his shoulders, swaying gently with the roll, his weight shifting on his bare feet; at about 1.5s the tiny warm light flickers up on the horizon at the left.
2.0s to 5.5s: He catches it: his head turns to the left toward the light and his body follows, his right hand joining his left on the rail; he leans forward a little, his head tilting, narrowing his eyes, his profile turning partly into view, the light flickering and steadying.
5.5s to 8.0s: A quiet, alert beat: he stays leaning on the rail, eyes fixed on the distant light, breathing a little faster, his shoulders tense, swaying with the deck; he keeps living the whole time.

PERFORMANCE
Alertness: a tired watchman suddenly awake; curiosity turning to unease, all in the body and a half-seen profile. Natural and loose, never stiff, never a statue, never theatrical.

PHYSICS
The bow rises and falls on the gentle swell; his shirt and mundu stir in the night breeze; the distant light flickers and sways with the swell, sometimes dipping behind a wave; the moon's path shimmers on the water.

LIGHTING
Night, natural and dark: faint cool moonlight from the half moon high on the right, a thin rim on Antony's right shoulder and hair; the deck in near-black shadow; the distant light only a tiny warm point on the horizon that lights nothing near. No glossy or polished look.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build. No spoken words and no voices.
0.0s–8.0s: the bow cutting through the swell, water hissing along the hull, the stem post creaking, a soft breeze, the faint creak of the rigging behind.
2.0s–5.5s: his hands sliding on the wooden rail; his breath catching once.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala period feature film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range that holds the faint moonlight and the deep night shadows in one frame; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Cool, dark, natural moonlit night palette.

POSITIVE LOCKS
Antony alone at the bow, seen from behind three-quarters, his profile turning partly into view only as he looks left at the light, never looking at the view; moving naturally the whole shot, never frozen. The distant light stays a tiny point on the horizon at the left; nothing else of it is seen. The moon stays high on the right. Nobody speaks. Runs the full 8 seconds.

FAILED s23-sh02 v1: Over the shoulder: he watches the fire

Attached: @antony20 (full) only; no start image, no plate

What went wrong

SB029 follows straight on from SB028 (same moment, same bow, same Antony), but the take had no relation to it: a different vessel, a different sky, Antony sitting instead of standing.

Why it failed

the previous approved take's last frame was not attached. Each generation remembers nothing, so without it the model rebuilt the scene from scratch.

Lesson L85: the rule now

1. If a shot carries on from the previous shot (same place, same moment, same people), its start image is the last frame of the previous approved take. It is required, not optional.
2. Keep the previous shot's camera, or move from it within the shot (push-in, pan). Cut to a new angle only when the story needs it, and then still attach the previous last frame as a reference plus the place's plate (L84).
3. Before writing the prompt, ask the creator for that last frame and save it in `scenes/<scene>/<shot>/approved/` (or `scenes/showreel/approved/`). If they don't have it, say the shot is at risk before delivering it.
4. The prompt's FIRST FRAME and the "Start image (0.0s)" reference line both say "the exact first frame: same place, same pose".

What the next version did

v2 started from the last frame of s23-sh01 as its start image and carried the bow plate (L84). Approved.

The prompt that failed

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SCENE
Late at night, 1998, on the open sea, at the bow of the wooden cargo uru. One continuous shot. Seen over Antony's right shoulder: the distant light he noticed is a small wooden fishing boat burning far off on the dark sea, ahead and to the left. He watches it, worried. Nobody speaks.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, sun-browned, short black hair; exactly the reference clothes: short-sleeve lavender-grey and white striped shirt and grey-green checked mundu, never a plain white shirt or trousers; thin silver chain, barefoot. 100% matches the reference.

WHAT IS IN FRAME
Only Antony's right shoulder, the back of his head and his right cheek in the foreground, the uru's dark wooden bow rail and the top of the curved stem post, the dark open sea, the faint horizon, and the small boat burning far away. Every frame looks like the film itself, with nothing from the making of it. No lettering anywhere.

THE BOW, LOOKING FORWARD-LEFT (0.0s–8.0s)
Seen from just behind Antony's right shoulder at his eye height, looking forward and to the left over the bow. Antony fills the right third of the frame, back three-quarters to the view, his right cheek and the line of his jaw just visible, his hands on the dark wooden bow rail with turned posts; the top of the uru's tall curved wooden stem post rises dark just left of him. Beyond, in the LEFT third of the frame, about half a kilometre away on the open sea: one small wooden fishing boat, low and narrow, burning along its whole length; flames a few metres high, sparks lifting, a column of dark smoke lit orange from below leaning to the right in the breeze, a long flickering orange reflection on the water toward us. The boat stays small and far; no people, no other boats, nothing else of it can be made out.

FIRST FRAME
Over Antony's right shoulder, his hands on the rail, looking forward-left; the small boat already burning far off in the left third of the frame.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
MS over the shoulder 40°: Antony's shoulder and head soft in the foreground; the burning boat sharp in the distance.
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CAMERA
A locked-off, perfectly steady view at eye height, rising and falling very gently with the swell, level horizon.

ACTION
0.0s to 2.0s: A quiet beat, never frozen: Antony leans on the rail watching the fire, breathing in his shoulders, swaying with the roll; the flames flicker and the smoke rolls up.
2.0s to 5.5s: The fire flares: a burst of flame and sparks climbs from the boat and the reflection brightens on the water; Antony straightens, his right hand tightening on the rail, his head tilting as he narrows his eyes, his jaw setting; he shifts his weight forward.
5.5s to 8.0s: A quiet, worried beat: he leans in again, breathing faster, his shoulders tense, swaying with the deck, eyes on the fire; he keeps living the whole time.

PERFORMANCE
Concern: a young sailor realising this is a boat on fire, and people may be on it; worry in the set jaw, the grip and the breathing, all from behind and the edge of his face. Natural and loose, never stiff, never a statue, never theatrical.

PHYSICS
The bow rises and falls on the gentle swell; his shirt collar and hair stir in the night breeze; the far flames flicker and lean with the breeze, sparks rising and fading; the smoke drifts right; the orange reflection breaks and re-forms on the swell; the burning boat rocks slightly on the water.

LIGHTING
Night, natural and dark: faint cool moonlight from the right, a thin rim on Antony's right shoulder, ear and hair; the near deck and rail in near-black shadow; the fire the only warm light, bright and orange far away, lighting its own smoke and the water around it, too far to light the uru or Antony. No glossy or polished look.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build. No spoken words and no voices.
0.0s–8.0s: the bow cutting through the swell, water hissing along the hull, the stem post creaking, a soft breeze; far off, the faint crackle of the fire carried on the wind.
2.0s–5.5s: his hand gripping the wooden rail; his breath catching once.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala period feature film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range that holds the bright distant fire and the deep night shadows in one frame; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Cool, dark, natural moonlit night palette with one small, far orange fire.

POSITIVE LOCKS
Antony seen from behind his right shoulder, back three-quarters, only the edge of his face, never looking at the view; moving naturally the whole shot, never frozen. The burning boat stays small and far, in the left third of the frame, the only fire; no people seen on it and nothing of what happened to it. Nobody speaks. Runs the full 8 seconds.

Scene 2: The crew at the rail: "there is someone in the water"



Worked: s23-sh05 v4 (approved frame)



Failed: s23-sh06 v5 (what came back)

What the second shot had to carry over

Element	Worked shot showed	Failed shot gave
People	Antony, Raghavan, Babu, Sasi: our crew	two strangers in Antony-style striped shirts
The burning boat	a tiny orange point, about 500 m away	a big burning boat right beside the uru (the prompt said 150 m)
Props	no lantern on a post	a lantern on a post that never existed
References	every man attached	Raghavan and Babu named many times, but not attached

WORKED s23-sh05 v4: The crew wake and gather at the rail

Attached: @urudeckc1platenight · @raghavan · @babu · @sasi · @aashaan (small, inside) · @antony20 (all full)

Why it worked

- Every person in frame was attached with his own sheet and placed: Antony nearest the bow, then Raghavan, Babu and Sasi, with Aashaan at the wheel inside.
- The deck plate carried the carved deckhouse, the lantern light and the moon.
- The fire stayed a tiny orange point on the horizon; only its glow was written.
- Group actions were staggered (L113), so the men woke and moved one after another.

The prompt that worked

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SCENE
Deep night, 1998, on the open sea, on the main deck of the big wooden cargo uru. One continuous shot. Woken by Antony's
shout, the three sleeping crewmen wake one after another, get up off their mats and hurry to the right-hand rail, where
Antony runs in from the bow; they all stare out at the sea toward the bow. Nobody moves to help. Inside the deckhouse
Aashaan leans to look out. Nobody speaks.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
Reference image (0.0s): the last frame of the earlier shot from this same view (s21-sh01), if kept: the same deck, mats,
deckhouse and men.
@urudeckc1platenight (0.0s–8.0s, full): the main deck looking aft exactly as in the reference: the carved wooden
deckhouse with its windows and half-open door glowing from one lantern inside, the wheel seen through the windows, mats
on the clear deck, the dark sea beyond the RIGHT rail, a half moon high on the left. 100% matches the reference.
@raghavan (0.0s–8.0s, full): Raghavan, about 60, thin and wiry, very dark weathered skin, short grey hair, grey
moustache, white cotton vest, red-and-white checked towel round his neck, white mundu. 100% matches the reference.
@babu (0.0s–8.0s, full): Babu, about 40, heavy-set, thick black moustache, red-and-white checked towel tied round his
head, off-white half-sleeve shirt open over a white vest, grey-brown checked lungi. 100% matches the reference.
@sasi (0.0s–8.0s, full): Sasi, about 35, lean, long thick black curly hair to the shoulders, full black beard, stained
off-white half-sleeve shirt open over a white vest, white mundu. 100% matches the reference.
@aashaan (0.0s–8.0s, full, small, inside the deckhouse): Aashaan, about 60, grey hair combed back, grey moustache, cream
half-sleeve shirt open over a white vest, white towel on his LEFT shoulder, white mundu. 100% matches the reference.
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, sun-browned, short black hair; exactly the reference clothes: short-
sleeve lavender-grey and white striped shirt and grey-green checked mundu, never a plain white shirt or trousers; thin
silver chain. 100% matches the reference.

WHAT IS IN FRAME
Only the main deck, the mats, the deckhouse with Aashaan inside, the right-hand rail with the dark sea beyond, the moon,
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and exactly five men: Raghavan, Babu, Sasi, Antony and Aashaan. Every frame looks like the film itself, with nothing from the making of it. No lettering anywhere.

THE DECK (0.0s–8.0s)
Seen from the main deck forward of the deckhouse at standing eye height, looking aft, exactly as in the reference. On the mats at the start: Raghavan on his back with the towel over his eyes, Babu on his side facing the right rail, Sasi asleep against the sacks. Inside the deckhouse, framed by the middle windows, Aashaan at the wheel. The right-hand rail runs down the right of the frame; beyond it the black sea.

FIRST FRAME
The three men asleep on their mats, Aashaan at the wheel inside the glowing deckhouse; the deck still.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
WS 63°, natural depth of field: every man and the deckhouse readable.

CAMERA
A locked-off, steady view at standing eye height, rising and falling gently with the swell, level horizon.

ACTION
0.0s to 2.0s: Each man wakes at his own moment, never together: at 0.3s Raghavan pulls the towel off his eyes and sits up; at 1.0s Babu pushes up on one elbow; at 1.6s Sasi lifts his head, still half asleep; each looks toward the bow, toward the camera; inside, Aashaan turns his head.
2.0s to 5.5s: At 2.0s Raghavan gets up first and hurries to the right-hand rail nearest the camera; at 2.8s Babu follows, slower; at 3.6s Sasi gets up last and comes after them; Antony runs in past the right edge of the frame from the bow to the rail beside Raghavan, his right arm pointing out over the sea toward the bow; inside the deckhouse Aashaan leans to the side window to look out.
5.5s to 8.0s: A tense beat: the four men at the right rail stare out toward the bow, a faint orange flicker on their faces; nobody climbs or moves to help; Babu shakes his head slowly, Sasi grips the rail, Raghavan breathes fast; Antony looks from the sea to the men and back. Everyone keeps moving.

PERFORMANCE
Fear and hesitation in the crew, urgency in Antony; bodies loose and real, never posed, never frozen.

PHYSICS
The deck rises and falls on the swell; the mats and cloth shift as the men get up; the lantern sways inside the deckhouse and the window glow moves.

LIGHTING
Deep night, natural and dark: warm lantern glow from the deckhouse windows and door onto the near planks; faint cool moonlight from the half moon high on the left; a faint flickering orange glow from beyond the right rail on the faces of the men there. No glossy look.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build. No spoken words and no voices.
0.0s–8.0s: water hissing along the hull, the rigging creaking; 0.5s–5.5s mats rustling and footsteps on the planks; 5.5s–8.0s quick, worried breaths; far off, the faint crackle of a fire.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala period film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range that holds the lantern-lit deckhouse and the dark deck in one frame; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Cool dark night with one warm lantern.

POSITIVE LOCKS
Exactly five men: Raghavan, Babu, Sasi and Antony at the RIGHT rail by the end, Aashaan inside the deckhouse at the wheel. Never moving together. Nobody climbs the rail or jumps. The moon stays high on the left. Nobody speaks. Runs the full 8 seconds.

FAILED s23-sh06 v5: Antony: the close-up line at the rail

Attached: reference image s23-sh05 last frame · @antony20 · @burningvallam (~150 m) · @selvan

What went wrong

the close-up came back with two men who are not our characters (both in Antony-style striped shirts), the burning vallam close and big beside the uru, a lantern on a post that never existed, and different words. Every earlier approved frame (s23-sh01, sh02, sh05) has the fire as a small far light on the horizon and our own crew at the rail. Each wrong generation costs credits.

Why it failed

1. The prompt named Raghavan and Babu many times (eyeline, performance, locks, "camera beside Raghavan's head") without attaching them; the model put two men in and built them from the only sheet attached, `@antony20`.
2. The prompt moved the fire to "about 150 metres" and attached `@burningvallam`, a close-up picture, so the boat was drawn close. No approved shot ever brought it near.
3. Nothing compared the prompt with the previous approved frames before it was sent.

Lesson L119: the rule now

1. Before every prompt, open the previous approved frames (last frame of the shot before, plus the earlier shots of the same moment) and fill a Continuity check table in the shot file: element · previous frames · this shot. Every person, the key prop's distance and size, light sides and props in hands. The prompt's CONTINUITY block (L118) is written from that table.
2. Anyone who could appear in the frame (the people the speaker talks to, people standing near him) is attached with their own sheet and placed explicitly (seen from behind, soft, where in the frame). Never name a person in the prompt without attaching them or saying plainly they are out of frame.
3. Distances do not change between shots unless a shot shows them changing. Write the distance in metres and the size in the frame ("a tiny orange point on the horizon") and check it in a 3D blocking camera view at real distances (`tools/blocking3d.py`, camera eye at the shot's position).
4. A close-up picture of a prop that must look far away is attached only with the size lock in its reference line, the location line and POSITIVE LOCKS.
5. Lock the head count: "exactly N people in frame: ...; no one else, no copies".

What the next version did

Every person who could appear was attached; the fire went back to about 500 m; the distance sheet (continuity/night-rescue-distances.md) and the Continuity check table started here.

The prompt that failed

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SCENE
Deep night, 1998, on the open sea, at the left-hand rail of the big wooden cargo uru. One continuous shot. Antony, his
back to the rail, the burning vallam and a man in the water behind him, orders Raghavan and Babu in Malayalam to bring a
rope. He is alone in the frame.
SPOKEN LANGUAGE: Malayalam. Every spoken word in this video is Malayalam, the exact Malayalam text given in quotes in
AUDIO. No English words are spoken.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
Reference image (0.0s–8.0s): the last frame of s23-sh05.
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, sun-browned, short black hair; exactly the reference clothes: short-
sleeve lavender-grey and white striped shirt and grey-green checked mundu, never a plain white shirt or trousers; thin
silver chain. Native Kollam-coast Malayalam speaker; warm, slightly hoarse young voice. 100% matches the reference.
@burningvallam (0.0s–8.0s, background only): the same burning boat, about 150 metres off behind Antony, small in the
frame; nobody on board. 100% matches the reference.
@selvan (0.0s–8.0s, background only, small): only his head and one raised arm in a soaked light-blue tiger-stripe
sleeve, in the water beside the burning boat; face not readable. 100% matches the reference.

CONTINUITY (carried over from the previous shot, the reference image)
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Same night, seconds later. Antony at the left-hand rail nearest the bow, same clothes and chain, his right arm just lowered from pointing out to sea; Raghavan just aft of him; Babu and Sasi further aft; Aashaan at the wheel inside. The burning vallam ahead-left of the boat, ~150 m off, the man in the water beside it. Lantern light from the deckhouse aft; night as dark as before.

THE RAIL (0.0s–8.0s)
From the deck a little aft of Antony and inboard, at his eye height, looking at him with the left-hand rail and the sea behind him. Only Antony is in frame. Behind him, over the dark rail with turned posts: the black sea and, right of frame centre, the burning vallam; beside its hull the small head and raised arm of a man in the water, lit orange. No lettering.
EYELINE: Raghavan and Babu stand just off the left edge of the frame; the camera is right beside Raghavan's head. Antony's head is turned a little toward them, his eyes on theirs about 20 degrees left of the lens: not right, not down, never into the lens.

FIRST FRAME
Antony at the rail, his right arm coming down from pointing, already looking at Raghavan and Babu just left of the lens; the fire behind him.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
MCU 30° easing to a tight MCU by 6.0s: Antony sharp; the burning boat and the man in the water behind him compressed, readable, a little softer.

CAMERA
Eye level, starting 2.0 m from his face; the camera travels straight toward him at about 0.25 km/h, easing in over the first second, keeping on through the line, and settles about 1.5 m away at 6.0s, then holds. Straight in, no arc, no sideways drift; a smooth weighted glide rising and falling gently with the swell. Focus on his eyes and mouth.

ACTION
0.0s to 3.0s: Antony lowers his right arm, eyes on Raghavan and Babu, breathing fast, his jaw setting; a short breath in.
3.0s to 4.2s: He gives his order in Malayalam, firm and loud enough over the sea, head steady, eyes on them.
4.2s to 8.0s: Silence. He says nothing more, mouth closed; nobody moves; he glances back over his shoulder at the man in the water, then grips the rail top with both hands, ready, breathing fast.

DIALOGUE RULES
Dialogue rules: whenever a character speaks, frame them in a medium close-up with their face filling at least a third of the frame height. The speaking face is turned toward the camera, no more than 30 degrees from the lens, upright and not lying sideways. Only one person speaks in the shot; everyone else keeps their mouth closed. The speaker's head stays steady during the line; head turns and gestures happen only in pauses between lines. The mouth is always fully visible, with nothing in front of the face, and the face is lit with soft, even frontal light. Natural, clearly articulated mouth movements matching the dialogue.
While a line is spoken, the speaker is the only person in the frame.

PERFORMANCE
Resolve: he has decided, fear pushed down. Real, conversational speech: natural breaths, not over-pronounced, not acted. Antony always looking at Raghavan and Babu while he speaks.

LIGHTING
Deep night: soft warm lantern light from aft evenly on his face; faint moonlight on his hair; the far fire lights its smoke and water. No glossy look.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build.
Spoken language: Malayalam only, not English and not a translation. Antony says the exact Malayalam words written in quotes below, in everyday Kollam coastal Malayalam pronunciation, and nothing else. Lip-sync exact; every word is spoken on camera by Antony, who is alone in frame. The line is spoken once, exactly as written.

3.0s to 4.2s: Antony, Kollam coast accent, firm and quick, stress on "കയറും", falling pitch. About 1.2 seconds.
"കയറും കൊണ്ടുവാ!"

Sound effects: water along the hull; the far fire. From 4.2s to 8.0s only these and his breathing: nobody speaks. No other voices.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range that holds the lantern light on his face and the far fire on the black sea in one frame; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Cool dark night, one far orange fire.

POSITIVE LOCKS
Antony alone in frame, MCU, back to the left-hand rail, eyes on Raghavan and Babu just left of the lens while he speaks, never into it. The camera only pushes straight in. Behind him, right of frame centre, the burning vallam about 150 metres off with the small man struggling beside it the whole shot. Silent for the last 3.8 seconds. Every word is

Malayalam. Runs the full 8 seconds.

When @antony20 says "കയറും കൊണ്ടുവാ!" let it be firm and decided, a young man telling older men what to do, right now

Scene 3: Cochin harbour: coming aboard the uru



Worked: s13-sh02 v2 (approved frame)



Failed: s13-sh03c v2 (what came back)

What the second shot had to carry over

Element	Worked shot showed	Failed shot gave
The gangplank	a long cleated plank with a rope rail, up to the SIDE rail by the deckhouse	a short ladder into the stern
Direction	the bow points back toward the camera, opposite to his walk	he walked straight down the deck toward the bow, as if from the stern
The quay	on his right, the uru moored beside it	gone: open water on both sides
The bag	strap on the LEFT shoulder, bag at the left hip	strap across the body, bag at the right hip

WORKED s13-sh02 v2: Antony walks to the uru

Attached: @harbourc3plate (full) · @antony20 (full) · @antonybag (full)

Why it worked

- The harbour plate fixed the quay, the uru and the gangplank.
- The sides were written as facts, the same as s13-sh01: the uru and the water on the LEFT, the warehouses on the RIGHT.
- @antonybag was attached and the shoulder was written: strap on the LEFT shoulder, bag at the left hip.
- A simple follow from behind that stops at the foot of the gangplank.

The prompt that worked

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SCENE
Hazy morning, 1998, the stone quay of an old cargo harbour at Cochin, Kerala. One continuous shot that follows close
behind Antony as he walks along the quay toward his moored wooden cargo uru and stops at the foot of its gangplank,
ready to board, at home here. Nobody speaks.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
@harbourc3plate (0.0s–8.0s, full): the end of the shot is exactly this view: the uru moored along the left side of the
quay, weathered blue-grey hull with rust streaks and a red-oxide waterline, one mast, the carved two-deck wooden
deckhouse with turned railings; a wooden gangplank with cleats rising from the quay up to its deck, rope railings beside
it; the stone quay along the right with stacked crates, burlap sacks and coils of coir rope, old warehouses with tiled
roofs further along on the right; calm glittering water and a low palm shore at the left. Throughout the shot the uru is
this vessel. 100% matches the reference.
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, sun-browned, short black hair combed neat; short-sleeve lavender-grey and
white striped shirt, grey-green checked mundu, thin silver chain, barefoot; a large, soft, faded beige canvas cloth
shoulder bag, slouchy, half full, about 40 cm wide, on one long cloth strap over his left shoulder, hanging at his left
hip; he carries it the whole shot. 100% matches the reference.
@antonybag (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony's shoulder bag, exactly as in the reference; worn over his left shoulder, hanging
at his left hip. 100% matches the reference.

WHAT IS IN FRAME
Only the quay, the uru and its gangplank, the cargo, the warehouses, the water, two workers and Antony. Every frame
looks like the film itself, with nothing from the making of it. The uru, the warehouses, the crates and the sacks carry
no lettering.

THE QUAY (0.0s–8.0s)
The same quay as the previous shot, seen the same way: the uru and the water on the LEFT, the warehouses and cargo on
the RIGHT, Antony walking away from the view toward the uru. At the start the uru is ahead and to the left, about ten
metres away, bow toward him; as he walks, its long side and the gangplank come into view on the left. Exactly two
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workers: one walks toward the view on the right with a burlap sack on his head and passes Antony; one stacks crates by the warehouses in the background. None of them looks at the view; nobody speaks. The gangplank is clear.

FIRST FRAME
Antony from behind, mid-stride, on the right third of the frame, seen from his back down to his waist, the bag at his left hip; ahead of him on the left the uru, bow toward him, its mast and deckhouse rising; the warehouses along the right.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
MS 47° from behind Antony, natural depth of field: Antony sharp, the uru and the quay ahead clearly readable, never a blurred backdrop.

CAMERA
The view travels forward close behind Antony at his walking pace, smooth and perfectly steady, at his shoulder height, about 1.5 metres behind him, keeping him on the right third; it slows and stops with him at 6.0s and then holds still, level horizon.

ACTION
0.0s to 6.0s: Antony walks along the quay toward the uru with a loose, natural gait: heel to toe on the stone, weight rolling from foot to foot, shoulders relaxed, his right arm swinging, his left hand on the bag strap, the bag swaying at his left hip. His head is turned a little to the left, his eyes on the uru the whole way. The sack-carrier passes him on the right; Antony gives him a small nod without breaking stride. The uru grows larger on the left until its side and the gangplank fill the left of the frame.
6.0s to 8.0s: He stops at the foot of the gangplank, his right foot beside its lowest cleat, and looks up along it to the deck and the deckhouse; he settles the bag strap on his left shoulder and holds there, breathing, about to step on.

PERFORMANCE
At-home confidence: unhurried, sure-footed, relaxed shoulders; he knows this quay and this vessel. His face is not seen; the confidence is in his walk and his posture.

PHYSICS
His shirt and mundu move with each step; the bag sways and settles. The uru rocks gently on the water; the gangplank shifts a little against the quay; the rope railings sag and lift; the water glitters.

LIGHTING
Hazy morning sun, 5000K, low and in front-left of the view: bright glitter on the water at the left, a soft warm rim along Antony's left shoulder and hair, soft shadows falling toward the right; the warehouse fronts in cool shade.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build. No spoken words and no voices.
0.0s–8.0s: water lapping against the hull and the quay wall, the hull creaking, ropes creaking, gulls and crows.
0.0s–6.0s: Antony's bare footsteps on the stone, a sack thudding down by the warehouses.
6.0s–8.0s: the gangplank creaking softly against the quay.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala period feature film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range that holds the glittering water and the shaded warehouse fronts in one frame; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Warm hazy morning palette.

POSITIVE LOCKS
The uru and the water stay on the left, the warehouses on the right, as in the previous shot. Antony is seen from behind the whole shot and walks away from the view toward the uru; he ends at the foot of the gangplank, not on it. One uru, matching the reference. The bag stays on his left shoulder. Nobody speaks. Runs the full 8 seconds.

FAILED s13-sh03c v2: Up the gangplank: he sees the crew

Attached: reference image s13-sh02 frame · @antony20 · @antonybag · @aashaan · @raghavan · @babu · @sasi · @suresh

What went wrong

the gangplank became a short ladder into the stern end; Antony walked straight along the centreline toward the bow, as if he had come from behind the boat. There was open water on both sides and no quay, as if the uru were at sea. The bag hung at his right hip on a strap across his body.

Why it failed

the prompt said "steps onto the deck ... looking forward along the main deck toward the bow" and never said that he arrives over the SIDE rail, which way the bow points from the quay, or that he has to turn. Given the shortest version, the model lined the gangplank up with the deck.

Lesson L128: the rule now

1. Whenever someone boards or leaves by a gangplank, write the side: "over the side rail, the quay behind him, the far rail and the water ahead of him".
2. Write the turn as a separate beat: "he turns to his LEFT to face the bow". The camera turns with him (it pans or arcs). Never let the camera look along the deck from the gangplank.
3. For any moored shot, write which rail the quay is beyond: when the deck view faces the bow, the quay is beyond the LEFT rail, with the gangplank's top at that rail.
4. The bag strap goes over his LEFT shoulder only and the bag hangs at his LEFT hip; never across the body.

What the next version did

v3 has him come over the SIDE rail, facing across the deck, then turn left to the bow; the quay is locked beyond the left rail; the bag strap is on his left shoulder only. (What worked in v2: the crew kept working and nobody posed, so L127 held.)

The prompt that failed

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SCENE
Mid-morning, 1998, the stone quay of the old cargo harbour at Cochin, Kerala, and the deck of Antony's big wooden cargo
uru moored beside it. One continuous follow shot close behind Antony: he walks up the gangplank, steps onto the deck
beside the deckhouse, and the deck opens up in front of him with the crew busy at their work, getting the uru ready to
sail. Nobody speaks.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
Reference image (0.0s–8.0s): the s13-sh02 frame: the same quay, uru, carved deckhouse, the same gangplank of cleated
planks with a rope rail up to the deck beside the deckhouse, the same light, Antony from behind.
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, short black hair, lavender-grey striped shirt, grey-green checked mundu,
barefoot, seen from behind.
@antonybag (0.0s–8.0s, full): his faded beige canvas bag: strap over his LEFT shoulder, bag at his LEFT hip.
@aashaan (5.0s–8.0s, full): Aashaan, about 60, grey moustache, cream shirt, white towel on his LEFT shoulder, white
mundu.
@raghavan (5.0s–8.0s, full): Raghavan, thin, about 60, white vest, checked towel round his neck.
@babu (5.0s–8.0s, full): Babu, heavy-set, checked towel tied round his head, checked lungi.
@sasi (5.0s–8.0s, full): Sasi, long curly hair, full beard, off-white shirt.
@suresh (5.0s–8.0s, full): Suresh, curly hair, cream shirt, green check mundu.

CONTINUITY (carried over from the previous shots)
Straight on from s13-sh02: Antony at the foot of the gangplank from behind, the uru and water at the LEFT, the quay at
the RIGHT, bag on his LEFT shoulder, barefoot, hazy warm sun. Balan has not arrived yet.

THE DECK (5.0s–8.0s)
From the top of the gangplank beside the deckhouse, looking forward along the main deck toward the bow: the thick wooden
mast about four metres ahead, a stack of burlap sacks lashed with coir rope beside it, coils of rope on the planks, the
blue-grey rails on both sides, The strip of deck between Antony and the mast is clear. Everyone is at the mast or
forward of it, each at a different distance, never in a row: Aashaan at the sacks beside the mast, pulling the lashing
tight; Raghavan sitting forward at the left, coiling rope; Sasi kneeling at the far rail, tying a lashing; Babu carrying
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a sack forward, away from the camera; Suresh at the forward hatch at the right, stacking a crate. No lettering.

FIRST FRAME
Exactly the reference: Antony from behind at the foot of the gangplank.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
MS 47° from behind Antony at shoulder height, natural depth of field; when the deck opens up, deep focus so the five men read clearly.

CAMERA
A smooth follow close behind Antony, two metres back, at his shoulder height: it follows him up the gangplank at his walking pace, rising with him, stops at the top of the gangplank as he steps onto the deck, then holds still over his right shoulder, looking forward along the deck. Level horizon, no shake.

ACTION
0.0s to 1.0s: Antony stands at the foot of the gangplank, a hand on the rope rail, the bag at his left hip.
1.0s to 4.5s: He walks up the gangplank with easy, practised steps, barefoot on the wooden cleats; the deckhouse grows larger at the left.
4.5s to 5.5s: He steps over the low rail onto the deck beside the deckhouse and stops, settling the bag strap on his left shoulder.
5.5s to 8.0s: The deck opens up in front of him, every man busy at his own work and his own pace. At 6.5s Aashaan, pulling the lashing tight, glances up at Antony's face for a moment and gives a small nod, then goes back to the rope. At 7.0s Babu, passing with the sack, throws Antony a quick look and walks on. Raghavan, Sasi and Suresh do not look up. Antony stands looking forward at Aashaan, his back to the camera.

EXPRESSIONS (every face, beat by beat)
Antony: seen from behind; shoulders loose and easy, his head lifting as the deck opens up, at home.
Aashaan: busy, brows drawn over the knot; at 6.5s a brief look up, a faint pleased softening of the eyes under the grey moustache; then back to work.
Babu: puffing a little under the sack, a quick friendly flick of the eyes at Antony, mouth closed, then eyes ahead.
Raghavan: absorbed in the rope, lips pressed, an old man's patient frown.
Sasi: concentrating on the knot, jaw set, face half hidden by his curly hair.
Suresh: busy and a little hurried, eyes on the crate.

PERFORMANCE
An ordinary working morning before sailing, weight in every sack and rope. A welcome without fuss: nobody stops working, nobody gathers, nobody poses.

LIGHTING
Exactly the reference's hazy warm morning sun; soft shadows on the planks.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build. No spoken words and no voices.
0.0s–8.0s: harbour ambience, gulls, water slapping between the hull and the quay; 1.0s–4.5s bare feet on the wooden cleats and the plank creaking; 4.5s a soft thump onto the deck; 5.5s–8.0s rope creaking, a sack thudding down, a crate set on wood.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Warm hazy morning palette.

POSITIVE LOCKS
One gangplank, exactly as in the reference. Antony seen from behind the whole shot, the bag strap on his LEFT shoulder, the bag at his left hip, barefoot. Exactly six men in the shot, one of each: Antony, Aashaan, Raghavan, Babu, Sasi, Suresh; no Balan, no copies, no extra people. Everyone keeps working; nobody looks at the camera, nobody poses, nobody waves. The deck between Antony and the mast stays clear. Nobody speaks. Runs the full 8 seconds.

Let it feel easy and warm: a young sailor coming aboard to a busy deck where he belongs